

Afghanistan, from March onwards India went into election mode. The drift was palpable and the balance was restored only with the five-day visit of US Secretary of State Hillary Clinton.

The visit, however, did fall far short of expectations with Hillary restraining herself from criticising Pakistan on tackling terror issues, hedging on charges that her administration was reneging on US commitments made for the nuclear deal and finding little meeting ground on issues such as WTO and climate change.

India delivered with an End User Agreement on defence purchases that would allow US companies to compete in big-ticket deals totalling \$40 billion—something the Opposition said stank of a sell-out. Yet despite the huge concession, South Block didn't seem to use it as a lever to get the US to pressure Pakistan to deliver on its terror commitments to India. With Manmohan's misstep at Sharm el-Sheikh, it also gave credence to the charges that the UPA Government had become in many ways a supplicant to US interests in the region.

Worse, with the UPA so focused on its relations with Pakistan and the US, a damaging drift had set into its relations with other countries that matter to India. In Sri Lanka, while

the UPA Government allowed President Mahinda Rajapakse to wipe out the LTTE and its chief V. Prabhakaran despite pressure from its allies in Tamil Nadu to stop the war, it has conceded considerable strategic ground to both China and Pakistan who supplied arms to the Sri Lanka Army. Nor has India come down forcefully enough on Rajapakse to spell out a new deal for the Tamils—the only way lasting peace can be ushered into the island. On Nepal, Maoist leader Prachanda thumbed his nose at India by making his first state visit as prime minister to China and then, when he was ousted, charged India with conspiracy. The new dispensation though continues to be weak giving India little comfort. In Bangladesh, despite having a supportive Prime Minister in Sheikh Hasina Wajed, India has not been able to get it to repatriate top Assam separatist leaders who have taken shelter in its territory.

India doesn't seem to have the stomach to take on an increasingly aggressive and nationalistic China. While trade relations between the two countries have grown significantly, there is very little progress on the border dispute. China recently reverted to its earlier position of disputing the legitimacy of Arunachal Pradesh as a part of India and staking claims on the monastery town of Tawang. There have been

China

Despite its aggressiveness and border provocations, India's response to China has been muted and ineffectual.

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Russia

Trade relations with all-weather friend Russia remain stagnant. Moscow arm-twists Delhi over the Gorshkov deal.

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